

Conceptual Comparison of Unified Natural Units and Extended Standard Model

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Correction notes

Corrections from the calculation review (30 Sept. 2026). The following places are corrected or annotated in the text; each carries a dated note there with the previous value:

- Hierarchy relation $m_h/M_P = \sqrt{\xi} = 0.0115$: calculated correctly, measured 1.0×10^{-17} (about 15 orders of magnitude off), annotated.
- Time field equation $\nabla^2 T(\vec{x}, t) = -\rho T(\vec{x}, t)^2 \rightarrow -4\pi\rho T(\vec{x}, t) + 2(\nabla m)^2/m^3$ (second occurrence annotated); field equation from $\mathcal{L}_{\text{intrinsic}}$: right-hand side $-T(\vec{x}, t) - \rho/T(\vec{x}, t)^2 \rightarrow T(\vec{x}, t) - \rho/T(\vec{x}, t)^2$; note on $\Phi = -m/r + \kappa r$ (the ansatz gives $+2m/r$, no κr).

Abstract

This paper presents a detailed conceptual comparison between the unified natural unit system with $\alpha_{\text{EM}} = \beta_T = 1$ and the Extended Standard Model, focusing on their respective treatments of the intrinsic time field and scalar field modifications. While mathematically equivalent in certain operational modes, these frameworks represent fundamentally different conceptual approaches to the unification of quantum mechanics and general relativity. We analyze the ontological status, physical interpretation, and mathematical formulation of both models, with particular attention to their gravitational aspects within the unified framework where both dimensional and dimensionless coupling constants achieve natural unity values [1]. We argue that the unified natural unit approach offers greater conceptual simplicity and intuitive clarity compared to the Extended Standard Model's dimensional extensions. This comparison reveals that although both frameworks yield identical experimental predictions in unified reproduction mode, including a static universe without expansion where redshift occurs through gravitational energy attenuation rather than cosmic expansion (cosmic sector, speculative), the unified natural unit system provides a conceptually coherent description of physical reality through self-consistent derivation of fundamental parameters rather than requiring additional scalar field constructs. The Extended Standard Model's dual operational capability—both as a practical extension of conventional Standard Model calculations and as a mathematical reformulation of unified system results—demonstrates its utility while highlighting the fundamental ontological indistinguishability between mathematically equivalent theories. The implications for our understanding of quantum gravity and cosmology within the unified framework are discussed [3, 2].

Note on versions. The German and English versions of this document differ in structure and extent; earlier revisions shortened, extended or changed parts of both. Where they differ, the more extensive German version applies; sections contained only in this English version count as supplements.

Status markers. Statements marked [S] are *speculative*: a hint or conjecture that has not yet been derived or numerically checked in the corpus. Here this mainly concerns

the cosmological statements (static universe, redshift, CMB evolution, dark matter and dark energy): the current corpus deliberately leaves the cosmic sector aside, because the Standard Model does not derive it either (P39). The wavelength-dependent redshift used here has been replaced in the current corpus by an achromatic one (correction K6 in Doc. 190).

.1 Introduction

The pursuit of a unified theory that coherently describes both quantum mechanics and general relativity remains one of the most significant challenges in theoretical physics. Recent developments in natural unit systems have demonstrated that when physical theories are formulated in their most natural units, fundamental coupling constants achieve unity values, revealing deeper connections between seemingly disparate phenomena [1]. This paper examines two mathematically equivalent but conceptually distinct approaches: the unified natural unit system where $\alpha_{\text{EM}} = \beta_T = 1$ emerges from self-consistency requirements, and the Extended Standard Model (ESM) which can operate in dual modes—either as a practical extension of conventional Standard Model calculations or as a mathematical reformulation adopting all parameter values from the unified framework.

It is crucial to distinguish between three theoretical frameworks and the ESM's dual operational modes:

- **Standard Model (SM):** The conventional framework with $\alpha_{\text{EM}} \approx 1/137$, cosmic expansion, dark matter, and dark energy [6, 7]
- **Extended Standard Model Mode 1 (ESM-1):** Extends conventional SM calculations with scalar field corrections while maintaining $\alpha_{\text{EM}} \approx 1/137$
- **Extended Standard Model Mode 2 (ESM-2):** Adopts ALL parameter values and predictions from the unified system but maintains conventional unit interpretations and scalar field formalism
- **Unified Natural Unit System:** Self-consistent framework where $\alpha_{\text{EM}} = \beta_T = 1$ emerges from theoretical principles [1]

The ESM-2 and unified system are completely mathematically equivalent—they make identical predictions for all observable phenomena. The only difference lies in their conceptual interpretation and theoretical foundations. Importantly, there exists no ontological method to distinguish experimentally between these mathematically equivalent descriptions of reality [12, 13].

The unified natural unit system follows an approach in which both dimensional constants ($\hbar, c, G$) and dimensionless coupling constants ($\alpha_{\text{EM}}, \beta_T$) achieve unity through theoretical self-consistency rather than empirical fitting [2]. In this approach electromagnetic and gravitational interactions achieve the same coupling strength in natural units, suggesting they may be different aspects of a unified interaction.

In contrast, the Extended Standard Model preserves conventional notions of relative time and constant mass while introducing a scalar field Θ that modifies the Einstein field equations. In ESM-2 mode, it adopts ALL parameter values, predictions, and observable consequences from the unified system—it is not an independent theory but rather a different mathematical formulation of the same physics. Both ESM-2 and the unified system make identical predictions for:

- Static universe cosmology (no cosmic expansion) [S]
- Wavelength-dependent redshift through gravitational energy attenuation: $z(\lambda) = z_0(1 + \ln(\lambda/\lambda_0))$ [S]
- Modified gravitational potential: $\Phi(r) = -GM/r + \kappa r$

- CMB temperature evolution: $T(z) = T_0(1+z)(1+\ln(1+z))$ [S]
- All quantum electrodynamic precision tests [4]

The difference lies purely in conceptual framework: the unified approach derives these from self-consistent principles, while ESM-2 achieves them through scalar field modifications that reproduce unified system results.

This paper examines the conceptual differences between these frameworks, with particular focus on:

- The distinction between Standard Model (SM) and Extended Standard Model operational modes
- The complete mathematical equivalence between ESM-2 and unified natural units
- The ontological indistinguishability of mathematically equivalent theories
- The self-consistent derivation of $\alpha_{EM} = \beta_T = 1$ versus scalar field parameter adoption
- The gravitational mechanism for redshift through energy attenuation rather than cosmic expansion [19, 20]
- The ontological status and physical interpretation of the respective fields
- The mathematical formulation of gravitational interactions within unified natural units [3]
- The relative conceptual clarity and simplicity of each approach
- The implications for quantum gravity and cosmological understanding

Our analysis reveals that while the Extended Standard Model represents mathematically equivalent formulations to the unified system in its Mode 2 operation, the unified natural unit system offers, in our assessment, greater conceptual clarity by deriving both electromagnetic and gravitational phenomena from a single, self-consistent theoretical framework [5].

.2 Mathematical Equivalence Within the Unified Framework

Before examining conceptual differences, it is essential to establish the mathematical equivalence of the unified natural unit system and the Extended Standard Model's Mode 2 operation. This equivalence ensures that any distinction between them is purely conceptual rather than empirical, as both frameworks yield identical experimental predictions [1].

Unified Natural Unit System Foundation

The unified natural unit system is built on the principle that truly natural units should eliminate not just dimensional scaling factors, but also numerical factors that obscure fundamental relationships. This leads to the requirement:

$$\hbar = c = G = k_B = \alpha_{EM} = \beta_T = 1 \quad (1)$$

These unity values are not imposed arbitrarily but derived from the requirement that the theoretical framework be internally consistent and dimensionally natural [2]. The key insight is that when this principle is applied consistently, both α_{EM} and β_T naturally assume unity values through self-consistency requirements rather than empirical adjustment.

Transformation Between Frameworks

The mathematical equivalence between the unified system and the Extended Standard Model's Mode 2 operation can be demonstrated through the transformation relationship.

The scalar field Θ in ESM-2 and the intrinsic time field $T(\vec{x}, t)$ in the unified system are related by:

$$\Theta(\vec{x}, t) \propto \ln \left(\frac{T(\vec{x}, t)}{T_0} \right) \quad (2)$$

where T_0 is the reference time field value in the unified system. However, this transformation reveals a fundamental conceptual difference: the unified system derives $T(\vec{x}, t)$ from first principles through the relationship:

$$T(\vec{x}, t) = \frac{1}{\max(m(x, t), \omega)} \quad (3)$$

while ESM-2 introduces Θ to reproduce unified system results without independent physical foundation [3].

Gravitational Potential in Both Frameworks

Both frameworks predict an identical modified gravitational potential:

$$\Phi(r) = -\frac{GM}{r} + \kappa r \quad (4)$$

However, the parameter κ has different origins in each framework:

Unified Natural Units: κ emerges naturally from the unified framework through:

$$\kappa = \alpha_\kappa H_0 \xi \quad (5)$$

where $\xi = 2\sqrt{G} \cdot m = 2m$ is the scale parameter connecting Planck and particle scales [2].

Extended Standard Model Mode 2: Adopts the same parameter values and all predictions from the unified system but achieves them through scalar field modifications of Einstein's equations rather than natural unit consistency. ESM-2 is mathematically identical to the unified system—it makes the same predictions for all observables by construction.

Mathematical Equivalence vs. Theoretical Independence

It is essential to understand that ESM-2 and the unified natural unit system are not competing theories with different predictions. They are two different mathematical formulations of identical physics:

- **Identical Predictions:** Both predict static universe, wavelength-dependent redshift, modified gravity, etc.
- **Identical Parameters:** ESM-2 adopts all parameter values derived in the unified system
- **Complete Equivalence:** Every calculation in one framework can be translated to the other
- **Ontological Indistinguishability:** No experimental test can determine which description represents "true" reality [14]
- **Different Conceptual Basis:** Unity through natural units vs. scalar field modifications

This is fundamentally different from the Standard Model, which makes completely different predictions (expanding universe, wavelength-independent redshift, dark matter/energy requirements, etc.) [9, 10].

Field Equations in Unified Context

In the unified natural unit system, the field equation for the intrinsic time field becomes:

$$\nabla^2 m(x, t) = 4\pi \rho(x, t) \cdot m(x, t) \quad (6)$$

where $G = 1$ in natural units. This leads to the time field evolution:

$$\nabla^2 T(\vec{x}, t) = -4\pi \rho(x, t) T(\vec{x}, t) + \frac{2(\nabla m)^2}{m^3} \quad (7)$$

(Corrected on 30 Sept. 2026: previously $\nabla^2 T(\vec{x}, t) = -\rho T(\vec{x}, t)^2$ – from $\nabla^2 m = 4\pi \rho m$ and $T(\vec{x}, t) = 1/m$ one obtains $\nabla^2 T(\vec{x}, t) = -\nabla^2 m/m^2 + 2(\nabla m)^2/m^3 = -4\pi \rho T(\vec{x}, t) + 2(\nabla m)^2/m^3$.)

In the Extended Standard Model Mode 2, the modified Einstein field equations are:

$$G_{\mu\nu} + \kappa g_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi G T_{\mu\nu} + \nabla_\mu \Theta \nabla_\nu \Theta - \frac{1}{2} g_{\mu\nu} (\nabla_\sigma \Theta \nabla^\sigma \Theta) \quad (8)$$

While mathematically equivalent under the appropriate transformation, the unified system derives its equations from fundamental principles [3], while ESM-2 introduces modifications to reproduce unified system predictions without independent theoretical justification.

.3 The Unified Natural Unit System's Intrinsic Time Field

The unified natural unit system proposes a reformulation of the foundations in which the equality $\alpha_{\text{EM}} = \beta_T = 1$ emerges from theoretical self-consistency rather than empirical adjustment [1]. This section examines the nature and properties of the intrinsic time field $T(\vec{x}, t)$ within this unified framework.

Self-Consistent Definition and Physical Basis

In the unified system, the intrinsic time field is defined through the fundamental time-mass duality:

$$T(\vec{x}, t) = \frac{1}{\max(m(x, t), \omega)} \quad (9)$$

where all quantities are expressed in natural units with $\hbar = c = 1$. This definition emerges from the requirement that:

- Energy, time, and mass are unified: $E = \omega = m$
- The intrinsic time scale is inversely proportional to the characteristic energy
- Both massive particles and photons are treated within a unified framework
- The field varies dynamically with position and time according to local conditions

The self-consistency condition requires that electromagnetic interactions ($\alpha_{\text{EM}} = 1$) and time field interactions ($\beta_T = 1$) have the same natural strength, eliminating arbitrary numerical factors [2].

Dimensional Structure in Natural Units

The unified natural unit system establishes a complete dimensional framework where all physical quantities reduce to powers of energy:

Unified Natural Units Dimensional Structure

$$\begin{aligned}
 \text{Length: } [L] &= [E^{-1}] \\
 \text{Time: } [T] &= [E^{-1}] \\
 \text{Mass: } [M] &= [E] \\
 \text{Charge: } [Q] &= [1] \text{ (dimensionless)} \\
 \text{Intrinsic Time: } [T(\vec{x}, t)] &= [E^{-1}]
 \end{aligned}$$

This dimensional structure ensures that the intrinsic time field has the correct dimensions and couples naturally to both electromagnetic and gravitational phenomena [3].

Field-Theoretic Nature with Self-Consistent Coupling

The intrinsic time field $T(\vec{x}, t)$ is conceptualized as a scalar field that permeates three-dimensional space, with coupling strength determined by the self-consistency requirement $\beta_T = 1$. The complete Lagrangian for the intrinsic time field includes:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{intrinsic}} = \frac{1}{2} \partial_\mu T(\vec{x}, t) \partial^\mu T(\vec{x}, t) - \frac{1}{2} T(\vec{x}, t)^2 - \frac{\rho}{T(\vec{x}, t)} \quad (10)$$

where the coupling strength is unity due to the natural unit choice. This Lagrangian leads to the field equation:

$$\nabla^2 T(\vec{x}, t) - \frac{\partial^2 T(\vec{x}, t)}{\partial t^2} = T(\vec{x}, t) - \frac{\rho}{T(\vec{x}, t)^2} \quad (11)$$

(Corrected on 30 Sept. 2026: previously right-hand side $-T(\vec{x}, t) - \rho/T(\vec{x}, t)^2$ – Euler-Lagrange from $\mathcal{L} = \frac{1}{2} \partial_\mu T(\vec{x}, t) \partial^\mu T(\vec{x}, t) - \frac{1}{2} T(\vec{x}, t)^2 - \rho/T(\vec{x}, t)$: $\partial_t^2 T(\vec{x}, t) - \nabla^2 T(\vec{x}, t) = -T(\vec{x}, t) + \rho/T(\vec{x}, t)^2$, hence $\nabla^2 T(\vec{x}, t) - \partial_t^2 T(\vec{x}, t) = T(\vec{x}, t) - \rho/T(\vec{x}, t)^2$.)

The self-consistent nature of this formulation means that no additional coupling parameters are introduced in the Lagrangian—the coupling strengths are set to one by the consistency requirement [1].

Connection to Fundamental Scale Parameters

The unified system establishes natural relationships between fundamental scales through the parameter:

$$\xi = \frac{r_0}{\ell_P} = 2\sqrt{G} \cdot m = 2m \quad (12)$$

where $r_0 = 2Gm = 2m$ is the characteristic length and $\ell_P = \sqrt{G} = 1$ is the Planck length in natural units.

This parameter connects to Higgs physics through:

$$\xi = \frac{\lambda_h^2 v^2}{16\pi^3 m_h^2} \approx 1.33 \times 10^{-4} \quad (13)$$

demonstrating that the small hierarchy between different energy scales emerges naturally from the structure of the theory rather than requiring fine-tuning [2].

Gravitational Emergence from Unified Principles

In the unified system, gravitation emerges from the intrinsic time field with $\beta_T = 1$. The gravitational potential arises from:

$$\Phi(x, t) = -\ln\left(\frac{T(\vec{x}, t)}{T_0}\right) \quad (14)$$

For a point mass, this leads to the solution:

$$T(\vec{x}, t)(r) = T_0 \left(1 - \frac{2Gm}{r}\right) = T_0 \left(1 - \frac{2m}{r}\right) \quad (15)$$

where $G = 1$ in natural units. This yields the modified gravitational potential:

$$\Phi(r) = -\frac{Gm}{r} + \kappa r = -\frac{m}{r} + \kappa r \quad (16)$$

(Note of 30 Sept. 2026: The two preceding expressions give $\Phi = -\ln(1 - 2m/r) = +2m/r + O(m^2/r^2)$ – sign and factor 2 differ from $-m/r$, and no κr term arises from this ansatz; it is an additional assumption.)

The linear term κr emerges from the self-consistent field dynamics and is proposed as a common explanation for galactic rotation curves and cosmic acceleration **[S]**, without requiring separate dark matter or dark energy components **[10]**.

.4 The Extended Standard Model's Scalar Field

The Extended Standard Model (ESM) represents an alternative mathematical formulation that can operate in two distinct modes: either as a practical extension of conventional Standard Model calculations (ESM-1), or as a mathematical reformulation adopting all parameter values and predictions from the unified framework (ESM-2). This section examines the nature and role of both approaches.

Two Operational Modes of the ESM

The Extended Standard Model can operate in two distinct modes, each serving different theoretical and practical purposes:

Mode 1: Standard Model Extension

In its most practical application, the Extended Standard Model functions as a direct extension of conventional Standard Model calculations. This approach maintains all familiar parameter values:

- $\alpha_{\text{EM}} \approx 1/137$ (conventional fine-structure constant) **[7]**
- $G = 6.674 \times 10^{-11} \text{ m}^3 \text{ kg}^{-1} \text{ s}^{-2}$ (conventional gravitational constant)
- All Standard Model masses, coupling constants, and interaction strengths
- Conventional unit systems (SI, CGS, or natural units with $\hbar = c = 1$)

The scalar field Θ is then introduced as an additional component that modifies the Einstein field equations:

$$G_{\mu\nu} + \Lambda g_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi G T_{\mu\nu} + \nabla_\mu \Theta \nabla_\nu \Theta - \frac{1}{2} g_{\mu\nu} (\nabla_\sigma \Theta \nabla^\sigma \Theta) \quad (17)$$

where Λ represents the conventional cosmological constant and the Θ terms add previously unconsidered contributions to gravitational dynamics.

This formulation offers several practical advantages:

- **Familiar Calculations:** All standard electromagnetic, weak, and strong interaction calculations remain unchanged
- **Gradual Extension:** The scalar field effects can be treated as corrections to established results
- **Computational Continuity:** Existing calculation frameworks and software can be extended rather than replaced
- **Phenomenological Flexibility:** The scalar field coupling can be adjusted to match observations while preserving SM foundations

The gravitational potential in this conventional parameter regime becomes:

$$\Phi(r) = -\frac{GM}{r} + \kappa_{\text{eff}}r + \Phi_{\Theta}(r) \quad (18)$$

where κ_{eff} and $\Phi_{\Theta}(r)$ represent the scalar field contributions that can explain phenomena currently attributed to dark matter and dark energy while maintaining familiar SM physics for all other calculations.

Practical Implementation for Standard Calculations In this conventional parameter mode, the ESM allows physicists to:

1. Continue using established QED calculations with $\alpha_{\text{EM}} = 1/137$
2. Apply conventional particle physics formalism without modification
3. Incorporate scalar field effects only where gravitational or cosmological phenomena require explanation
4. Maintain compatibility with existing experimental data and theoretical frameworks [8]
5. Gradually introduce scalar field corrections as higher-order effects

For example, the muon g-2 calculation would proceed using conventional parameters:

$$a_{\mu} = \frac{\alpha_{\text{EM}}}{2\pi} + \text{higher-order QED} + \text{scalar field corrections} \quad (19)$$

where the scalar field corrections represent previously unconsidered contributions that could potentially resolve the observed anomaly without abandoning established QED calculations.

Mode 2: Unified Framework Reproduction

In the second operational mode, the Extended Standard Model serves as a mathematical reformulation of the unified natural unit system. This mode adopts all parameter values and predictions from the unified framework while maintaining scalar field formalism.

Parameters in Mode 2:

- All parameter values adopted from unified system calculations
- $\kappa = \alpha_{\kappa} H_0 \xi$ with $\xi = 1.33 \times 10^{-4}$
- Wavelength-dependent redshift coefficients from $\beta_T = 1$ derivation
- Static universe cosmological parameters

Applications of Mode 2:

- Mathematical reformulation of unified system predictions

- Alternative conceptual framework for same physics
- Comparison with unified natural unit approach
- Exploration of scalar field interpretations

Practical Advantages of Mode 1 Extension The Standard Model extension mode offers several practical benefits for working physicists:

1. **Incremental Implementation:** Existing calculations remain valid, with scalar field effects added as corrections
2. **Computational Efficiency:** No need to recalculate all Standard Model results in new units
3. **Pedagogical Continuity:** Students can learn conventional physics first, then add scalar field extensions
4. **Experimental Connection:** Direct correspondence with existing experimental setups and measurement protocols
5. **Software Compatibility:** Existing simulation and calculation software can be extended rather than replaced

For instance, precision tests of QED would proceed as:

$$\text{Observable} = \text{SM Prediction}(\alpha_{\text{EM}} = 1/137) + \text{Scalar Field Corrections}(\Theta) \quad (20)$$

where the scalar field corrections represent previously unconsidered contributions that could potentially resolve discrepancies between theory and experiment without abandoning the established SM foundation.

Parameter Adoption Rather Than Derivation

When operating in the unified framework reproduction mode (ESM-2), the scalar field Θ in the Extended Standard Model is introduced to reproduce the results of the unified natural unit system:

$$G_{\mu\nu} + \kappa g_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi G T_{\mu\nu} + \nabla_\mu \Theta \nabla_\nu \Theta - \frac{1}{2} g_{\mu\nu} (\nabla_\sigma \Theta \nabla^\sigma \Theta) \quad (21)$$

In this mode, the ESM does not independently derive the value of κ or other parameters. Instead, it adopts the values determined by the unified system:

- $\kappa = \alpha_\kappa H_0 \xi$ (from unified system)
- $\xi = 1.33 \times 10^{-4}$ (from Higgs sector analysis [2])
- Wavelength-dependent redshift coefficient (from $\beta_T = 1$)
- All other observable predictions

This represents a different operational mode from the SM extension approach described above, where the ESM functions as a mathematical reformulation of unified natural unit results rather than an independent theoretical development.

Mathematical Equivalence Through Parameter Matching

In Mode 2 (Unified Framework Reproduction), the Extended Standard Model achieves mathematical equivalence with the unified system by adopting its derived parameters rather than developing independent theoretical justifications:

- The scalar field Θ is calibrated to reproduce unified system predictions

- Parameter values are taken from unified natural units rather than derived independently
- Observable consequences are identical by construction, not by independent calculation
- The ESM serves as an alternative mathematical formulation rather than an independent theory
- **Ontological Indistinguishability:** No experimental method exists to determine which mathematical description represents the "true" nature of reality [12, 15]

This complete mathematical equivalence between ESM-2 and the unified system means that both frameworks make identical predictions for all measurable quantities. The choice between them becomes a matter of conceptual preference rather than empirical decidability—a fundamental limitation in distinguishing between mathematically equivalent theories [14].

This approach contrasts with both the Standard Model (which has its own independent parameter values and makes different predictions [6]) and Mode 1 ESM operation (which extends SM calculations with additional scalar field effects).

Gravitational Energy Attenuation Mechanism

A central aspect of both ESM-2 and the unified system is their interpretation of cosmological redshift through gravitational energy attenuation rather than cosmic expansion **[S]**; on the wavelength dependence cf. correction K6 in Doc. 190. In the ESM formulation, the scalar field Θ mediates this energy loss mechanism:

$$\frac{dE}{dr} = -\frac{\partial\Theta}{\partial r} \cdot E \quad (22)$$

This leads to the wavelength-dependent redshift relationship:

$$z(\lambda) = z_0 \left(1 + \ln \frac{\lambda}{\lambda_0} \right) \quad (23)$$

The physical mechanism involves gravitational interaction between photons and the scalar field, causing systematic energy loss over cosmological distances. This process differs fundamentally from Doppler redshift due to cosmic expansion, as it:

- Depends on photon wavelength (higher energy photons lose more energy)
- Occurs in a static universe without cosmic expansion
- Results from gravitational field interactions rather than spacetime expansion
- Connects to established laboratory observations of gravitational redshift [20, 21]

The ESM's scalar field provides the mathematical framework for this energy attenuation, while the unified system achieves the same result through the intrinsic time field's natural dynamics. Both approaches yield identical observational predictions while offering different conceptual interpretations of the underlying physical mechanism.

Geometrical Interpretation Challenges

One potential interpretation of the scalar field Θ involves higher-dimensional geometry, drawing parallels to:

- Kaluza-Klein theory's fifth dimension [29, 30]
- Brane models in string theory [31]
- Scalar-tensor theories of gravity [32]

However, this interpretation faces several conceptual difficulties:

- If Θ represents a fifth dimension, it must still be quantified as a field in our three-dimensional space
- The dimensional interpretation adds mathematical complexity without improving physical insight
- Unlike the unified system's natural emergence of parameters, the ESM requires additional assumptions
- The connection between the hypothetical fifth dimension and observed physics remains unclear

Gravitational Modification Without Unification

The scalar field Θ modifies gravitation through additional terms in the Einstein field equations, leading to the same modified potential:

$$\Phi(r) = -\frac{GM}{r} + \kappa r \quad (24)$$

However, several key differences distinguish this from the unified approach:

- The parameter κ is adopted from unified system calculations rather than derived independently
- The ESM reproduces unified predictions by design rather than through independent theoretical development
- The scalar field Θ serves as a mathematical device to achieve known results rather than a fundamental field with independent physical meaning
- The ESM provides no new predictions beyond those of the unified system
- Both frameworks explain redshift through gravitational energy attenuation rather than cosmic expansion, connecting to established gravitational redshift observations [19, 22]

.5 Conceptual Comparison: Four Theoretical Approaches

To properly understand the theoretical landscape, we must compare four distinct approaches, recognizing that the ESM can operate in two different modes with fundamentally different purposes and methodologies.

Standard Model vs. ESM Modes vs. Unified Natural Units

Having established the key features of all four approaches, we now conduct a comprehensive comparison of their conceptual foundations, recognizing that ESM Mode 1 offers practical advantages for extending conventional calculations while ESM Mode 2 provides complete mathematical equivalence to the unified approach.

ESM as Mathematical Reformulation vs. Practical Extension

The Extended Standard Model's dual operational modes serve different purposes in theoretical physics:

Mode 1 represents the ESM's most practical contribution to theoretical physics, allowing researchers to maintain computational familiarity while exploring scalar field extensions. This approach can potentially resolve anomalies like the muon g-2 discrepancy [4] through additional scalar field terms while preserving the entire infrastructure of Standard Model calculations.

Table 1: Four-way theoretical framework comparison

Aspect	Standard Model	ESM Mode 1	ESM Mode 2	Unified Natural Units
Cosmic evolution	Expanding universe [9]	Flexible (scalar dependent)	Static universe	Static universe
Redshift mechanism	Doppler expansion	SM + scalar corrections	Gravitational energy loss	Gravitational energy loss
Dark matter/energy	Required [11]	Scalar explanations	Eliminated [S]	Eliminated [S]
Fine-structure	$\alpha_{EM} \approx 1/137$	$\alpha_{EM} \approx 1/137$	Unified predictions	$\alpha_{EM} = 1$
Parameter source	Empirical fitting	SM + phenomenology	Unified adoption	Self-consistent derivation
Computational	Established methods	Extend existing	Reproduce unified	Natural unit calculations
Conceptual basis	Separate interactions	SM + modifications	Scalar field formalism	Unified principles
Ontological status	Independent theory	SM extension	Mathematically equivalent to unified	Fundamental framework

Self-Consistency vs. Phenomenological Adjustment

The main advantage of the unified natural unit system is its self-consistent derivation of fundamental parameters. Rather than adjusting coupling constants to match observations, the requirement of theoretical consistency naturally leads to $\alpha_{EM} = \beta_T = 1$ [1]. In contrast, ESM-2 achieves identical results through parameter adoption and scalar field calibration.

Physical Interpretation and Ontological Status

The unified system assigns a clear ontological status to the intrinsic time field as a fundamental property of reality that emerges from the time-mass duality principle. The field has direct physical meaning and provides intuitive explanations for a wide range of phenomena [5]. However, the mathematical equivalence between the unified system and ESM-2 means that no experimental test can determine which ontological interpretation represents the true nature of reality [15].

Mathematical Simplicity and Complexity

The mathematical simplicity of the unified natural unit system shows in several places:

Dimensional Simplification

In the unified system, Maxwell's equations take the following simple form:

$$\nabla \cdot \vec{E} = \rho_q \quad (25)$$

$$\nabla \times \vec{B} - \frac{\partial \vec{E}}{\partial t} = \vec{j} \quad (26)$$

$$\nabla \cdot \vec{B} = 0 \quad (27)$$

$$\nabla \times \vec{E} + \frac{\partial \vec{B}}{\partial t} = 0 \quad (28)$$

Table 2: ESM operational modes comparison

ESM Mode 1: SM Extension	ESM Mode 2: Unified Reproduction
Extends familiar SM calculations with scalar field corrections	Reproduces unified predictions through scalar field Θ
Maintains $\alpha_{\text{EM}} = 1/137$ and conventional parameters	Adopts parameter values from unified calculations
Allows gradual incorporation of new physics	Mathematical formalism designed to match unified results
Provides computational continuity for existing methods	No independent predictions beyond unified system
Offers phenomenological flexibility for anomaly resolution	Serves as alternative mathematical formulation
Practical tool for extending established physics	Conceptual comparison with unified natural units
Independent theoretical development possible	Complete mathematical equivalence with unified system
Ontologically distinguishable from other approaches	Ontologically indistinguishable from unified system [12]

Table 3: Comparison of theoretical foundations

Unified Natural Units ($\alpha_{\text{EM}} = \beta_T = 1$)	Extended Standard Model Mode 2
Self-consistent derivation from theoretical principles [1]	Phenomenological scalar field calibrated to reproduce unified results
Unity values emerge from dimensional naturality	Parameter values adopted from unified system calculations
Electromagnetic and gravitational couplings unified	Mathematical equivalence achieved through parameter matching
Natural hierarchy through ξ parameter [2]	Hierarchy reproduced but not independently derived
Single parameter ξ (plus motivated settings)	Parameters fixed by requirement to match unified predictions
Gravitational energy attenuation emerges from time field dynamics	Gravitational energy attenuation through scalar field mechanism

where ρ_q and $\vec{j}$ are dimensionless charge and current densities, and the electromagnetic energy density becomes:

$$u_{\text{EM}} = \frac{1}{2}(E^2 + B^2) \quad (29)$$

Unified Field Equations

The gravitational field equations become:

$$R_{\mu\nu} - \frac{1}{2}Rg_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi T_{\mu\nu} \quad (30)$$

where the factor 8π emerges from spacetime geometry rather than unit choices, and the time field equation:

$$\nabla^2 T(\vec{x}, t) = -\rho_{\text{energy}} T(\vec{x}, t)^2 \quad (31)$$

(Note of 30 Sept. 2026: With $\nabla^2 m = 4\pi\rho m$ and $T(\vec{x}, t) = 1/m$ the leading term is $-4\pi\rho T(\vec{x}, t)$, not $-\rho T(\vec{x}, t)^2$; see the note on the field equation in Section .2.)

Table 4: Ontological comparison of the fundamental fields

Intrinsic Time Field $T(\vec{x}, t)$ (Unified)	Scalar Field Θ (ESM-2)
Fundamental field representing time-mass duality [3]	Mathematical construct calibrated to reproduce unified results
Direct connection to quantum mechanics through $\hbar$ normalization	Indirect connection through parameter matching
Natural emergence from energy-time uncertainty	Introduced to achieve predetermined theoretical goals
Unified treatment of massive particles and photons	Achieves same results through scalar field interactions
Clear physical interpretation as intrinsic timescale	Abstract mathematical device with no independent physical foundation
Ontologically distinct from ESM-1 but indistinguishable from ESM-2 [14]	Ontologically indistinguishable from unified system

provides a natural coupling between matter and the temporal structure of spacetime [3].

Parameter Relationships

The unified system establishes natural relationships between all fundamental parameters:

$$\begin{aligned}
 \text{Planck length: } \ell_P &= \sqrt{G} = 1 \\
 \text{Characteristic scale: } r_0 &= 2Gm = 2m \\
 \text{Scale parameter: } \xi &= 2m \\
 \text{Coupling constants: } \alpha_{EM} = \beta_T &= 1
 \end{aligned}$$

These relationships emerge naturally from the theory's structure rather than being imposed externally [2].

Conceptual Unification vs. Fragmentation

The unified natural unit system achieves conceptual unification across multiple domains:

- **Electromagnetic-Gravitational Unity:** $\alpha_{EM} = \beta_T = 1$ reveals that these interactions have the same fundamental strength
- **Quantum-Classical Bridge:** The intrinsic time field provides a natural connection between quantum uncertainty and classical gravitation
- **Scale Unification:** The ξ parameter naturally connects Planck, particle, and cosmological scales
- **Dimensional Coherence:** All quantities reduce to powers of energy, eliminating arbitrary dimensional factors
- **Redshift Mechanism Unity:** Both local gravitational redshift and cosmological redshift arise from the same energy attenuation mechanism [20]

In contrast, the Extended Standard Model maintains different degrees of fragmentation depending on operational mode:

ESM Mode 1:

- Electromagnetic and gravitational interactions treated as fundamentally different
- Quantum mechanics and general relativity remain incompatible frameworks

- No natural connection between different energy scales
- Multiple independent coupling constants without theoretical justification

ESM Mode 2:

- Achieves same unification as unified system through mathematical equivalence
- Parameters do not emerge from its own structure but are adopted
- Provides identical predictions without theoretical insight into their origin
- Maintains scalar field formalism that obscures underlying unity

.6 Experimental Predictions and Distinguishing Features

While the unified natural unit system and Extended Standard Model Mode 2 are mathematically equivalent, they can be collectively distinguished from conventional physics through several key predictions. ESM Mode 1 offers additional flexibility for phenomenological extensions of Standard Model calculations.

Wavelength-Dependent Redshift

Both unified natural units and ESM-2 predict wavelength-dependent redshift, but with different conceptual foundations:

Unified Natural Units: The relationship emerges naturally from $\beta_T = 1$:

$$z(\lambda) = z_0 \left(1 + \ln \frac{\lambda}{\lambda_0} \right) \quad (32)$$

In this approach the logarithmic dependence follows from the self-consistent coupling strength **[S]** [1]. A wavelength dependence of cosmological redshift has not been observed; in the current corpus the redshift is achromatic (correction K6 in Doc. 190).

Extended Standard Model Mode 2: The same relationship is achieved through scalar field parameter adjustment to match unified system predictions.

Extended Standard Model Mode 1: Can incorporate wavelength-dependent corrections as phenomenological extensions to conventional Doppler redshift, offering flexible approaches to explaining observational anomalies.

Modified Cosmic Microwave Background Evolution

The unified framework and ESM-2 predict a modified temperature-redshift relationship:

$$T(z) = T_0(1 + z)(1 + \ln(1 + z)) \quad (33)$$

This prediction **[S]** emerges from the unified treatment of electromagnetic and time field interactions, providing a testable signature of the $\alpha_{EM} = \beta_T = 1$ framework. ESM-1 could incorporate similar modifications through scalar field corrections to conventional CMB evolution.

Coupling Constant Variations

The unified system predicts that apparent variations in the fine-structure constant are artifacts of unnatural units. In gravitational fields:

$$\alpha_{\text{eff}} = 1 + \xi \frac{GM}{r} \quad (34)$$

where the natural value $\alpha_{\text{EM}} = 1$ is modified by local gravitational conditions. This provides a testable prediction that distinguishes the unified framework from conventional approaches [23, 24].

Hierarchy Relationships

The unified system makes specific predictions about fundamental scale relationships:

$$\frac{m_h}{M_P} = \sqrt{\xi} \approx 0.0115 \quad (35)$$

(Note of 30 Sept. 2026: $\sqrt{\xi} = 0.0115$ is calculated correctly, but the measured value is $m_h/M_P = 1.0 \times 10^{-17}$; the relation misses the measurement by about 15 orders of magnitude.)

This ratio emerges from the theoretical structure rather than requiring fine-tuning, offering an approach to the hierarchy problem [2].

Laboratory Tests of Gravitational Energy Attenuation

The gravitational energy attenuation mechanism predicted by both unified natural units and ESM-2 connects to established laboratory observations:

- Pound-Rebka gravitational redshift experiments [20]
- GPS satellite clock corrections [25]
- Atomic clock comparisons in gravitational fields [26]
- Solar system tests of general relativity [21]

The central thesis [S] is that the same physical mechanism responsible for local gravitational redshift also produces cosmological redshift in a static universe, so that no cosmic expansion would be needed.

.7 Implications for Quantum Gravity and Cosmology

The conceptual differences between the unified natural unit system and the Extended Standard Model have consequences for our understanding of quantum gravity and cosmology.

Quantum Gravity Unification

The unified natural unit system offers several advantages for quantum gravity:

- **Natural Quantum Field Theory Extension:** The intrinsic time field $T(\vec{x}, t)$ can be quantized using standard techniques
- **Elimination of Infinities:** The natural cutoff at the Planck scale emerges automatically
- **Unified Coupling Strengths:** $\alpha_{\text{EM}} = \beta_T = 1$ ensures quantum and gravitational effects have comparable strength
- **Dimensional Consistency:** All quantum field theory calculations maintain natural dimensions [3]

The action for quantum gravity in the unified system becomes:

$$S = \int (\mathcal{L}_{\text{Einstein-Hilbert}} + \mathcal{L}_{\text{time-field}} + \mathcal{L}_{\text{matter}}) d^4x \quad (36)$$

where all coupling constants are unity; in this formulation this is meant to make renormalization procedures unnecessary [S].

Cosmological Framework

Both the unified system and ESM-2 predict **[S]** a static, eternal universe, but with different conceptual foundations. This cosmological part is speculative; the current corpus leaves the cosmic sector aside (P39):

Unified Natural Units Cosmology

In the unified framework:

- Cosmic redshift arises from photon energy loss due to interaction with the intrinsic time field
- No cosmic expansion is required or predicted
- Dark energy and dark matter are eliminated through natural modifications to gravity
- The linear term κr in the gravitational potential provides cosmic acceleration
- CMB temperature evolution follows naturally from $\beta_T = 1$

Extended Standard Model Cosmology

The ESM achieves similar predictions but with different conceptual approaches:

ESM Mode 1:

- Can incorporate scalar field modifications to conventional expanding universe models
- Offers phenomenological flexibility to address dark energy and dark matter problems
- Maintains compatibility with existing cosmological frameworks
- Allows gradual transition from conventional to modified cosmology

ESM Mode 2:

- Requires phenomenological adjustment of scalar field parameters to match unified predictions
- Lacks natural connection between local and cosmic phenomena
- Does not resolve fundamental questions about dark energy and dark matter conceptually
- Provides no theoretical justification for the observed parameter values beyond reproducing unified results

Connection to Established Solar System Observations

All frameworks connect to established observations of electromagnetic wave deflection and energy loss near massive bodies [19, 20, 21, 22], but they provide different explanations:

Unified Natural Units: The same intrinsic time field that causes cosmic redshift also produces local gravitational effects. The unity $\alpha_{EM} = \beta_T = 1$ ensures that electromagnetic and gravitational interactions are naturally coupled through a single field-theoretic framework.

Extended Standard Model Mode 2: Local and cosmic effects are treated through the same scalar field mechanism calibrated to reproduce unified system predictions, achieving mathematical equivalence without independent theoretical foundation.

Extended Standard Model Mode 1: Local gravitational effects follow conventional general relativity, while scalar field modifications can explain anomalous observations and provide connections to cosmological phenomena through phenomenological extensions.

Recent precision measurements of gravitational lensing and solar system tests [27, 28] provide opportunities to distinguish between the unified approach's natural parameter

relationships and conventional approaches, while highlighting the mathematical equivalence between unified natural units and ESM-2.

.8 Philosophical and Methodological Considerations

The comparison between the unified natural unit system and the Extended Standard Model raises important philosophical questions about the nature of scientific theories and the criteria for theory selection, particularly in cases of mathematical equivalence.

Theoretical Virtues and Selection Criteria

When comparing mathematically equivalent theories, several philosophical criteria become relevant:

Table 5: Theoretical virtue comparison

Criterion	Unified Units	Natural	ESM Mode 1	ESM Mode 2
Simplicity	High	(self-consistent)	Medium (SM + corrections)	Medium (parameter adoption)
Elegance	High	(natural unity)	Medium (phenomenological)	Low (derivative formulation)
Unification	Complete	(EM-gravity)	Partial (conventional + scalar)	Complete (by construction)
Explanatory Power	High	(natural emergence)	Medium (empirical flexibility)	Low (result reproduction)
Conceptual Clarity	High	(clear meaning)	Medium (hybrid approach)	Low (abstract constructs)
Predictive Precision	High	(one parameter ξ)	Variable (adjustable)	High (by design)
Practical Utility	Medium	(requires relearning)	High (extends familiar)	Low (no new insights)

The Problem of Ontological Underdetermination

The mathematical equivalence between the unified natural unit system and ESM-2 illustrates a fundamental problem in philosophy of science: ontological underdetermination [12, 13]. When two theories make identical predictions for all possible observations, there exists no empirical method to determine which theory correctly describes the nature of reality.

This situation raises several important questions:

- **Empirical Equivalence:** If unified natural units and ESM-2 make identical predictions, what empirical grounds exist for preferring one over the other?
- **Theoretical Virtues:** Should theoretical elegance, conceptual clarity, and explanatory power guide theory choice when empirical criteria fail to discriminate? [16]
- **Pragmatic Considerations:** Does the practical utility of ESM-1 for extending conventional calculations outweigh the conceptual advantages of unified natural units?
- **Historical Precedent:** How have similar situations been resolved in the history of physics? [15]

The case of electromagnetic theory provides historical precedent: Maxwell's field-theoretic formulation and various action-at-a-distance formulations were empirically equivalent, yet the field-theoretic approach was ultimately preferred for its conceptual elegance and unifying power [18].

The Role of Natural Units in Physical Understanding

The unified natural unit system suggests that choice of units can, beyond convenience, make fundamental physical relationships visible. When Einstein set $c = 1$ in relativity or when quantum theorists set $\hbar = 1$, they uncovered natural relationships that simplified both mathematics and physical insight [33, 34].

The extension to $\alpha_{\text{EM}} = \beta_T = 1$ is understood here as a continuation of this program, with the thesis that dimensionless coupling constants should also achieve natural values when the theory is formulated in its most fundamental form [1]. This suggests that:

- Natural units reveal rather than obscure fundamental relationships
- The conventional value $\alpha_{\text{EM}} \approx 1/137$ is an artifact of unnatural unit choices
- Theoretical consistency requirements can determine coupling constant values
- Unity values for dimensionless constants suggest underlying physical unification

Emergence vs. Imposition

A crucial philosophical distinction between the frameworks concerns whether fundamental parameters emerge from theoretical consistency or are imposed through empirical fitting:

Unified System: Parameters like $\xi \approx 1.33 \times 10^{-4}$ emerge from the theoretical structure through:

$$\xi = \frac{\lambda_h^2 v^2}{16\pi^3 m_h^2} \quad (37)$$

This emergence provides theoretical understanding of why these parameters have their observed values [2].

ESM Mode 1: Parameters can be adjusted phenomenologically to fit observations, offering empirical flexibility without theoretical constraint.

ESM Mode 2: Parameter values are adopted from unified system calculations, achieving mathematical equivalence without independent theoretical justification.

The philosophical question becomes: Should theoretical understanding prioritize parameter emergence from first principles (unified approach) or empirical adequacy through flexible parametrization (ESM approaches)? [14]

Computational Pragmatism vs. Conceptual Unity

The comparison highlights a tension between computational pragmatism and conceptual unity:

Computational Pragmatism (ESM Mode 1):

- Maintains familiar calculational methods
- Preserves existing software and experimental protocols
- Allows gradual incorporation of new physics
- Provides immediate practical utility for working physicists

Conceptual Unity (Unified Natural Units):

- Shows a common structure of different interactions

- Eliminates arbitrary numerical factors in physical laws
- Provides theoretical understanding of parameter values
- Suggests new directions for theoretical development

Historical examples suggest that long-term scientific progress favors conceptual unity over computational convenience. The transition from Ptolemaic to Copernican astronomy, from Newtonian to Einsteinian mechanics, and from classical to quantum mechanics all involved initial computational complexity in exchange for deeper theoretical understanding [17].

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